



THE CEO WHO DREAMS BIG

Arundhati Bhattacharya distinguished herself as SBI Chairperson. At Salesforce, she is leading the digital transformation with ease

BY KRISHNA GOPALAN

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RUNDHATI BHATTACHARYA WATCHES A lot of Netflix. “It could be any web series,” she says. Her favourite right now is *Sullivan’s Crossing*, a heartwarming series focused on neurosurgeon Maggie Sullivan, who flees a scandal in Boston to her rural Nova Scotia hometown. A welcome break in view of the challenging task Bhattacharya has set for herself—to grow Salesforce into a force to reckon with in the digital world. Before joining Salesforce as Chairperson for South Asia, she was the Chairperson of State Bank of India (SBI), the country’s largest bank.

From her first day of professional employment in 1977 with SBI, this post-graduate in English literature, who spent her formative years in Bhilai and then Bokaro, has never treaded the safe path. After four decades with SBI, she is equally at home in the world of AI-driven customer relationship management.

A BUNCH OF SMALL, BIG THINGS

In the lives of most professionals, a few instances make all the difference. For Bhattacharya, it was an assignment in Kharagpur, when she led a team for the first time. Her boss was in Burdwan, a good 130 km away, and in a world without mobile phones, it was quite an experience. Decisions had to be taken quickly, by the person on the ground.

“I faced a strongly unionised branch, and it taught me a lot about negotiation. I learnt how to do a lot with limited resources,” she says, sitting in her office in Mumbai’s Bandra Kurla Complex. Later, she moved to the US for a stint in New York and took the “extremely tough” decision to send her daughter back home for a year. At that point, her aunt was a great source of support. “I still don’t know if I took the right decision.”

Then, there was a stint as chief general manager for new businesses based out of Mumbai. “Opening a new business in a public sector bank is not easy but it turned out to be the most productive period of my life,” she says. For one, Bhattacharya had to deal with a new set of regulators. “Till then, it was only the Reserve Bank of India. Now, for a private equity fund, I had to talk to Sebi and RBI, and for general insurance, IRDAI; to operationalise the fund management company, I also interacted with PFRDA.”

That set her up for other new assignments, one of them being SBI Capital Markets. “The SBI name opened a

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